OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Shoalhaven's 2026 satisfaction survey: why the method changed and where the full report is

Sent 15 October 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 30 October 2026

OPEN LETTER

To: Mr Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer, Shoalhaven City Council
Copied to: Clr Peter Wilkins, Deputy Mayor; all councillors; the Chairperson, Audit, Risk and Improvement Committee

From: Stephen Prothero, Eye on Shoalhaven Council

Date: 15 October 2026
Subject: The 2026 community satisfaction survey: why the method changed, whether comparison with earlier surveys was affected, and when the full report will be public

This letter is widely distributed to community and consultation groups
STATUS OF THIS LETTER
This is a public open letter to the Chief Executive Officer. It is published by Eye on Shoalhaven Council as a matter of public interest journalism.

It is not a complaint. It is not a complaint under Council's Complaint Handling Policy, and it is not to be registered, assessed or managed as one.
It is not a Code of Conduct complaint. It does not allege a breach of the Code of Conduct by any person, and it is not to be referred to the Complaints Coordinator, a conduct reviewer or the Office of Local Government.
It is not an access application. It is not an application under the Government Information (Public Access) Act 2009 (NSW), formal or informal, and no statutory time limit is started by it.
It is not a request for service. It does not ask Council to take action, to make a decision, or to review a decision.
It is a set of questions put to a public official in the same way a journalist puts questions to the head of an organisation. The Chief Executive may answer all, some or none of the questions, and may do so in whatever form and at whatever time he chooses. Some questions can be answered in a line and others may need work. If the Chief Executive intends to comment on any question, a short reply to this email saying so is all that is needed.
Replies will be published in full. If no reply is received, that will be recorded as it stands.

Mr Constance,

Council has published an Executive Summary of its 2026 community satisfaction survey. It reports that 57% of respondents rated Council's overall performance "average or above", down from 73% in 2023.

I am writing because the survey method changed between 2023 and 2026, and a reader could reasonably conclude that the change made comparison with earlier surveys harder. I put that as a question, not a finding. I also ask about the full report.

1. What the public record shows

• The 2023 survey, by Taverner Research Group, was a phone (CATI) survey of 401 residents aged 18 and over, with a stated margin of error of ±4.9%, asking about the previous 12 months and rating 48 services. Its full report ran to 74 pages and included the questionnaire.

• The 2026 survey, by Place Score, drew 430 respondents through an email invitation, with an age band starting at 15, asking about the previous two years and rating 50 services. The public material I could find is an Executive Summary. I found no margin of error, weighting statement, questionnaire or response rate.

• The 73% figure for 2023 does not appear in the Taverner report. It matches 34% satisfied plus 39% neutral. Taverner's own result was 34% satisfied and 27% dissatisfied, with a mean score of 3.04, which it described as substantially below the 3.22 average for comparable regional councils.

• The 2026 summary describes the result as reflecting "a broader trend" across councils. I found no source or ranking for that statement.

• I could not find the full 2026 report on Council's website. The "report" page I found appears to link an older record.

I have also noted that Council's February 2023 news release described an online survey open to the whole community running alongside Taverner's random phone sample. Question 4 asks which results the 2023 headline figures rest on.

2. Questions

Question 1. Why did Council change the survey method, provider, question period, age range and number of services between 2023 and 2026? Who made each decision, on what date, and on what advice? Please provide any report, brief or approval that records the reasons.

Question 2. Did Council or Place Score consider whether the changes would affect comparison with the 2020 and 2023 results? Was comparability with earlier surveys a requirement in the brief to Place Score? If it was, what did Place Score do to preserve it, and if it was not, why not?

Question 3. Were any steps taken to test the effect of the change, such as running the old and new methods side by side? If not, how does Council say the 73% to 57% comparison is

valid? Why does the published summary carry no warning that the two surveys are not like for like?

Question 4. Which 2023 results does the 73% figure rest on: the Taverner phone sample alone, or that sample together with the open online survey? How was 73% calculated, and why was it presented in place of Taverner's published 34% satisfied and 27% dissatisfied?

Question 5. Was the 2026 sample random, how were respondents selected and invited, what was the response rate, and how was the result weighted? What is the margin of error, and how many of the 430 respondents were under 18?

Question 6. Council describes the result as reflecting "a broader trend" across councils. What is the source, and where did Shoalhaven rank against comparable councils in 2026, given that in 2023 its mean score of 3.04 was below the 3.22 comparison average?

Question 7. The summary leads with services residents ranked 49th and 50th of 50 for importance (the rubbish tip and cemeteries). Residents ranked sealed roads first for importance (85%) and gave it the lowest score. Why were the highest performing services featured ahead of the lowest scoring services residents care about most?

Question 8. Value for money from rates and responsible financial management were not asked in 2023 and sit among the weakest 2026 results. Why were they added, and will Council commit to asking them in the same form in future so that a trend can be shown?

Question 9. What did the 2026 survey cost, and what did the 2023 survey cost? Did the contract with Place Score require a full report, a questionnaire and a methodology statement? If it did, were they delivered?

Question 10. When will the full 2026 report, the questionnaire, the weighting and sampling statement and the verbatim comments be made public? If they will not be, please say why. Will Council also publish the 2023 Taverner report on the same page so that residents can compare the two?

I ask for a response by Friday 30 October 2026. If any question cannot be answered, please say which and why, so the reason can be reported accurately.

I intend to publish this letter and any reply in full at steveprothero.substack.com and in the Eye on Shoalhaven Council group. If no reply is received by 30 October I will report that plainly.

No adverse finding has been made against any councillor, officer or contractor, and none is implied. The factual statements in this letter are drawn from Council's published survey material and news release and from the 2023 Taverner report. Where I have inferred something it is stated as an inference or put as a question. I will correct any error promptly and with the same prominence.

Yours sincerely,
Stephen Prothero

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Documents relied on: Shoalhaven City Council, Service Satisfaction Results page; Council 2026 Executive Summary (Place Score); Council Community satisfaction survey page; Council news release, February 2023; Taverner Research Group, Shoalhaven City Council Community Satisfaction Survey, April 2023; Eye on Shoalhaven Council, article of 15 October 2026 on the survey results.
